

PERSONAL HERBALISM REFERENCE

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Compiled 2019 to present. Last updated January 2026.

This is a working reference for herbs I grow, forage, or use regularly.

Not a medical guide. Not advice for clients. Personal notes only.

CHAMOMILE (*Matricaria chamomilla*)

Growing notes: Annual. Direct sow in early spring after last frost (Asheville: mid-April).

Full sun or part shade. Thin to 6 inches. Deadhead frequently to extend bloom.

My bed on the east side of the yard is best for it.

Harvest: Harvest flowers when petals begin to reflex downward from the center disk.

Morning harvest, after dew dries. Spread on a screen to dry, not piled.

Drying time: 1 to 2 weeks in a warm spot with airflow. I use the porch beams.

Store in a sealed glass jar out of direct light. Label with the harvest date.

Shelf life: 12 months for strong flavor, up to 18 months for milder use.

Preparation: Standard infusion: 1 tablespoon dried flowers per 8 oz just-boiled water.

Steep covered 10 minutes. Covering keeps the volatile oils in the cup.

Uses: Relaxation and sleep support. Mild digestive upset (Owen occasionally gets a small diluted cup, Dr. Yoon approved). Skin: cooled strong brew as a rinse for irritated skin.

Works on Hazel's occasional eczema. Gifting: dried flowers in jars for Jess and Loretta.

LEMON BALM (*Melissa officinalis*)

Growing notes: Hardy perennial in Western NC. Grows aggressively. Keep it bordered.

Mine is in the right-side raised bed, contained by a metal edging strip Neil installed.

Harvest: Cut stems 4 to 6 inches from the base. Harvest before flowering through summer.

Dry same as chamomile, or use fresh in tea.

Preparation: Fresh: a small handful of leaves in a cup, pour over just-boiled water, steep 5 min.

Dried: 1 tablespoon per cup, steep 8 to 10 minutes.

Uses: Anxiety and nervous tension: my go-to for a hard shift or a call that went sideways.

Paired with chamomile in my Mountain Morning blend. Sleep: combined with valerian in Night Watch.

Lemon balm lemonade: fresh leaves, honey, and cold water. Kids both drink it.

Contraindications I track: Avoid in pregnancy without a provider okay. I do not offer it to clients.

PEPPERMINT (*Mentha x piperita*)

Growing notes: Aggressive spreader. Grown in a buried bucket planter to contain the roots.

Preparation: Fresh: a few sprigs, steep 5 to 7 minutes. Dried: 1 teaspoon per cup.

Peppermint is potent. Use less than you think.

Uses: Alertness after a long birth. Digestive: Neil and I both use it for a heavy dinner.

Mountain Morning blend: peppermint and lemon balm, 2 parts lemon balm to 1 part peppermint.

Overproduction: I have more peppermint than I can use. Dry and gift aggressively each summer.

NETTLE (*Urtica dioica*)

Growing notes: I do not grow this. I forage it. Good stands along the greenway near Hominy Creek.

Harvest in early spring before plants flower, when they are under 12 inches. Wear gloves.

I take no more than one-third of any stand. Roots stay in the ground.

Preparation: Drying completely eliminates the sting. Do not handle fresh nettle without gloves.

Dried leaf infusion: 2 tablespoons per cup, steep 10 to 15 minutes, covered. Dark and earthy.

Nourishing herbal infusion: a full ounce dried nettle in a quart jar, pour over just-boiled water, steep 4 hours or overnight. Strain and drink through the day. Rich in minerals.

Uses: Nutritive infusion weekly, spring through fall. Neil takes a daily nettle capsule (1000mg)

March through May for seasonal allergies. Known safe stand: east bank of Hominy Creek near the Amboy Road crossing.

TEA BLENDS I MAKE

Mountain Morning (my daily morning tea)

Ratio: 2 parts lemon balm, 1 part peppermint. Steep: 8 minutes, covered.

Character: Bright, lemony, clean. Wakes up without caffeine.

Night Watch (evening)

Ratio: 3 parts chamomile, 2 parts lemon balm, 1 part valerian root

Note on valerian: I buy this dried from Asheville Herb Shop, not homegrown.

Valerian has a strong earthy smell that some people dislike. Honey helps.

Steep: 12 minutes, covered. Character: Earthy and floral. Sedating within 30 to 45 minutes.

Sourcing:

Asheville Herb Shop, Lexington Avenue: valerian root, passionflower, dried elderberry

French Broad Food Co-op bulk section: dried herbs when I run short between harvests

Mountain Gardens, Burnsville NC: educational visits, occasional plant starts

Foraging: Hominy Creek (nettle, blackberry leaf), forest edges near Black Balsam road (yarrow)